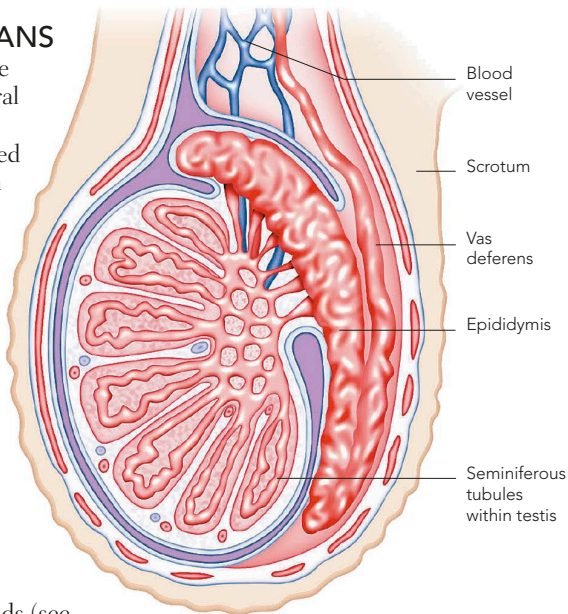


MALE REPRODUCTIVE SYSTEM

THE MALE SYSTEM PRODUCES SEX CELLS (GAMETES) CALLED SPERM. UNLIKE FEMALE EGG MATURATION, WHICH OCCURS IN CYCLES AND CEASES AT MENOPAUSE, SPERM PRODUCTION IS CONTINUOUS, REDUCING GRADUALLY WITH AGE.

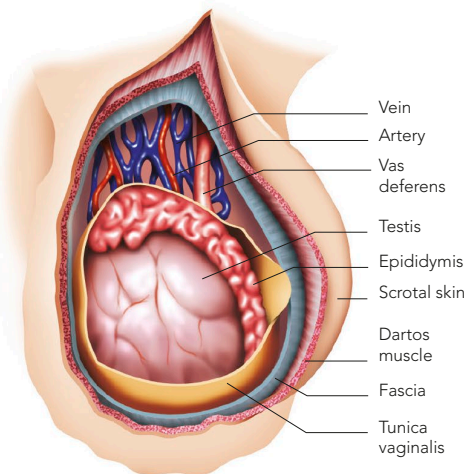
THE REPRODUCTIVE ORGANS

The male reproductive organs include the penis, two testes (testicles), several storage and transport ducts, and supporting structures. The oval-shaped testes lie outside the body in a pouch of skin called the scrotum, where they maintain the optimum temperature for making sperm – approximately 3°C (5°F) lower than body temperature. Testes are glands responsible for making sperm and the sex hormone testosterone. From each testis, sperm pass into a coiled tube – the epididymis – for the final stages of maturation. They are stored in the epididymides until they are either broken down and reabsorbed, or ejaculated – forced by movement of seminal fluid from the accessory glands (see p.254) down a duct called the vas deferens.



INSIDE THE SCROTUM

The scrotum contains two testes, where sperm are manufactured within tubes called seminiferous tubules, and the two epididymides, where sperm are stored. Each epididymis is a tube about 6m (20ft) long, which is tightly coiled and bunched into a length of just 4cm (2in).



SCROTAL LAYERS

Each testis is covered by a thin tissue layer, the tunica vaginalis, and a layer of connective tissue called fascia. An outer layer called the dartos muscle relaxes in hot weather, dropping the testes to keep them cool, and draws them up in cold weather so they do not become too chilled. The spermatic cord suspends each testis within the scrotum: it contains the testicular artery and vein, lymph vessels, nerves, and the vas deferens.